one would not take it remiss even if despite one's earnest entreaties and supplication Irwin need give no consideration to the issue at all? And this, at exactly the time that Gandhi was negotiating with Irwin in the matter of calling off the Civil Disobedience Movement. Take it or leave it is what Gandhi was suggesting to Irwin. He was doing so in a perfunctory and half-hearted manner. The technique was designed to backfire. It was calculated not to work, for otherwise there was no need for Gandhi to have expressed himself in this way. And backfire it did.

The only difficulty for Gandhi lay in the date of 24 March 1931, which was the day that Gandhi and Bose would arrive on a train from Calcutta to Karachi. Karachi Congress on 26 March where the Gandhi–Irwin Pact was up for ratification. So he spoke again about Bhagat Singh. The meeting is recounted by Irwin. The viceroy refers to Gandhi and records how following a discussion on the pact on 19 March 1931, '[a]s he was leaving, he asked if he might mention the case of Bhagat Singh' again. Gandhi had learnt from the press that 24 March was the planned date of execution. However, '[t]his was an unfortunate day as it coincided with the arrival of the new President of the Congress at Karachi and there would be much popular excitement'.[18] If this is right, then Gandhi's only concern throughout seems to have been, not whether the young men were spared but when they should be hanged, and if they were hanged at the time of the Karachi Congress session that would take the limelight off the session. For Gandhi, it was politically convenient if the death sentence was carried out before the Karachi Congress session. And so it was. Small wonder that Irwin then saw no need to commute Bhagat Singh's death sentence. Small wonder that within a week of this meeting Irwin promptly proceeded with the execution on the night of 23 March 1931 before the President of Congress arrived in Karachi on 24th March. Tantalizingly, at the eleventh hour, Gandhi realized that he was still not off the hook as far as public opinion would be concerned. History would judge him harshly for his ambivalence. Contemporary India too would damn him. He had to now ask for commutation directly, even if the hour was late. So Gandhi wrote a final bizarre letter on the day of the execution on 23 March 1931 to the viceroy.